AGENT SKILLS

Installed. Invoked. Followed.

INSTALLED
the skill exists in the library

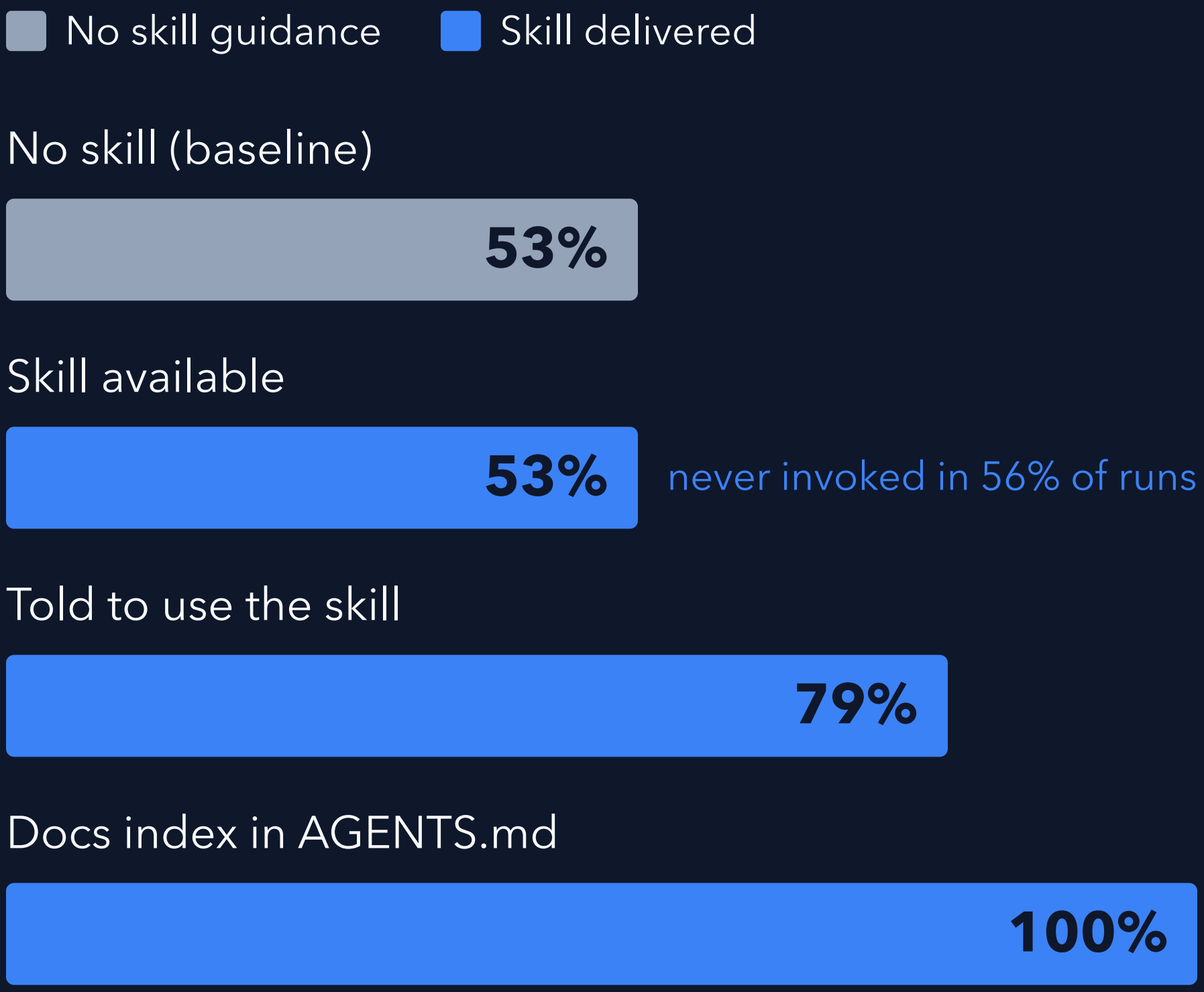
INVOKED
the agent chose to load it

FOLLOWED
it held under pressure

Most scoreboards only count the first.

VERCEL CODING-AGENT EVAL · PASS RATE

Same skill, four ways to deliver it



Source: Vercel, "AGENTS.md outperforms skills in our agent evals," Jan 2026 (vendor-run eval)

INSIDE THE HARNESS

Four places a skill gets lost

STAGE	LOST WHEN	FIX
LISTED	description summarizes the workflow	**“Use when…” triggers only**
CHOSEN	too many skills compete	**2–3 focused skills per task**
KEPT	compaction trims long skills	**short skills (Superpowers v7.0.1)**
ENFORCED	it’s only a request	**a hook for the must-nots**

Claude Code lists name + description only; the body loads when chosen.

Sources: Superpowers writing-skills SKILL.md and v7.0.1 release notes, 2026 · SkillsBench (arXiv 2602.12670), 2026 · Claude Code skills and hooks docs, 2026

FOUR LAYERS SHAPE AN AGENT

Where does an agent's identity live?

ALWAYS ON	CLAUDE.md / AGENTS.md every turn
PERSONA	output styles replace the default prompt
ON DEMAND	skills only when chosen
GUARANTEED	hooks run by the harness, not the model

?

Behavior that adds up, or a persona that persists?

The question for Agentics, Nov 4.

Alex Yedi

Sources: Claude Code docs (output styles, hooks), 2026 · Agentics Spotlight invite, 2026